BUSINESS CASE · CONSULTING SKILLS SHOWCASE

HESG Grant Portal

Process Improvement

Diagnosing and redesigning the Australian Government's Higher Education Supplementary Grant (HESG) application portal to eliminate operational bottlenecks and reduce submission failure rates.

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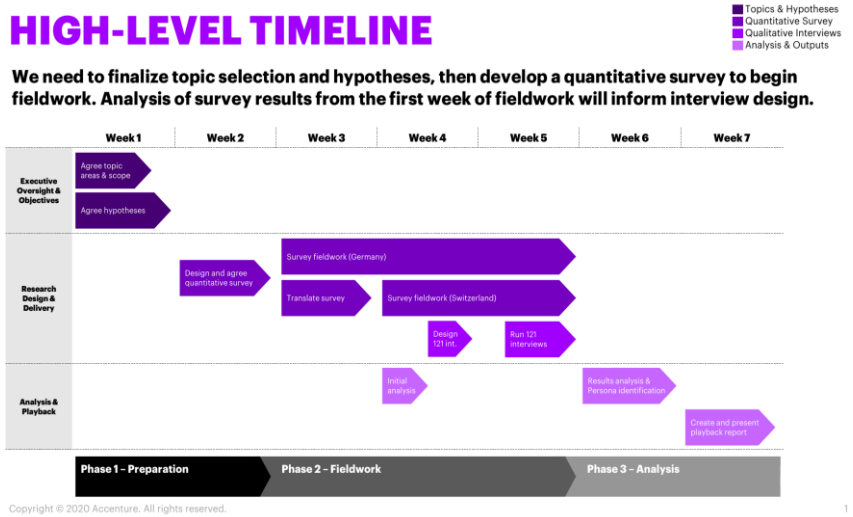
Context: Australian Government education grant portal under pressure.

Project Overview

Client	Australian Government — HESG Dept.
Scope	Online grant application portal for higher education students
Objective	Diagnose process failures & design optimised portal workflow
Engagement	7-week consulting engagement: Research → Analysis → Recommendations
Volume	~4,015 monthly visits from eligible students across Australia

Project Timeline



Phase 1 — Research Design	Phase 2 — Fieldwork & Analysis	Phase 3 — Recommendations

The portal was systematically failing students, not protecting them.

53%

Submission Failure Rate

Over half of all grant applications were rejected or failed

55%

Login Bounce Rate

Students dropped off before even reaching the application form

4,015

Users/Month Affected

Monthly visits impacted by the dysfunctional portal

Core Problem Statement

The HESG digital portal suffered from **chronic UX design failures and absent data validation,** resulting in a 53% application failure rate. The majority of rejections were caused by preventable user errors — not policy violations. Staff resources were diverted from processing to manually chasing incorrectly submitted claims.

ROOT CAUSES:

- No input validation
- Private data exposed
- Receipt upload: 2MB limit
- No duplicate detection
- Free-text date fields

Four consulting methods, structured around evidence-based diagnosis.

01 Data Analysis

Quantitative

Why: To identify objective failure patterns across 4,015 monthly visits

> Excel Screen Traffic Data

> Individual Login Data (May 2019)

> Bounce rates, dwell times, submission KPIs

02 Process Mapping

UX & Flow

Why: To trace every step of the user journey and locate friction points

> 9-screen end-to-end flow documented

> BPMN As-Is diagram created

> 6 critical UX failure points mapped

03 Stakeholder Research

Qualitative

Why: To capture ground-level experience from users and operations staff

> 10+ student feedback quotes synthesised

> 6 staff feedback insights coded

> Root cause clustering applied

04 Strategic Prioritisation

Decision Framework

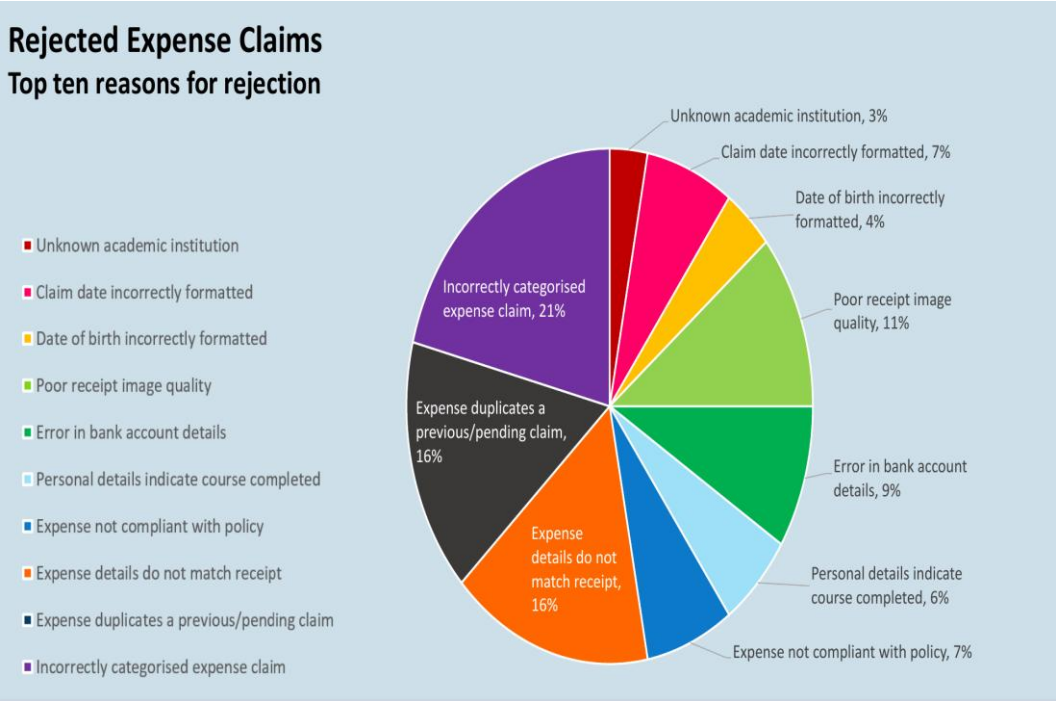
Why: To evaluate 15 competing initiatives and build an actionable roadmap

> BCG 2x2 Impact/Effort Matrix

> $7.8M initiative portfolio assessed

> Phased roadmap: Quick Wins > Strategic

64% of rejections are preventable — driven by UX failures, not policy.



WHAT THE DATA REVEALED

64% — **preventable errors**

Formatting, categorisation & duplicates — fixable with UX validation

21% — **#1 reason: wrong category**

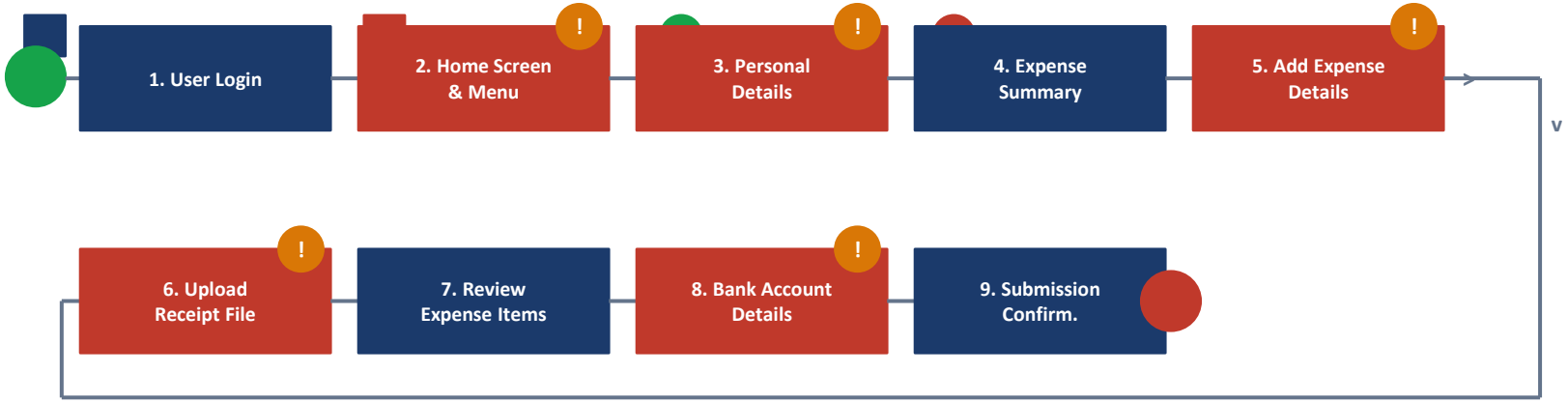
Students don't understand expense classification — needs guided UI

9% — **bank detail errors**

Manual entry with zero validation — creates months-long payment delays

ISO 9001:2015 — Principle 6: Evidence-Based Decision Making · Every recommendation is directly traceable to a data finding

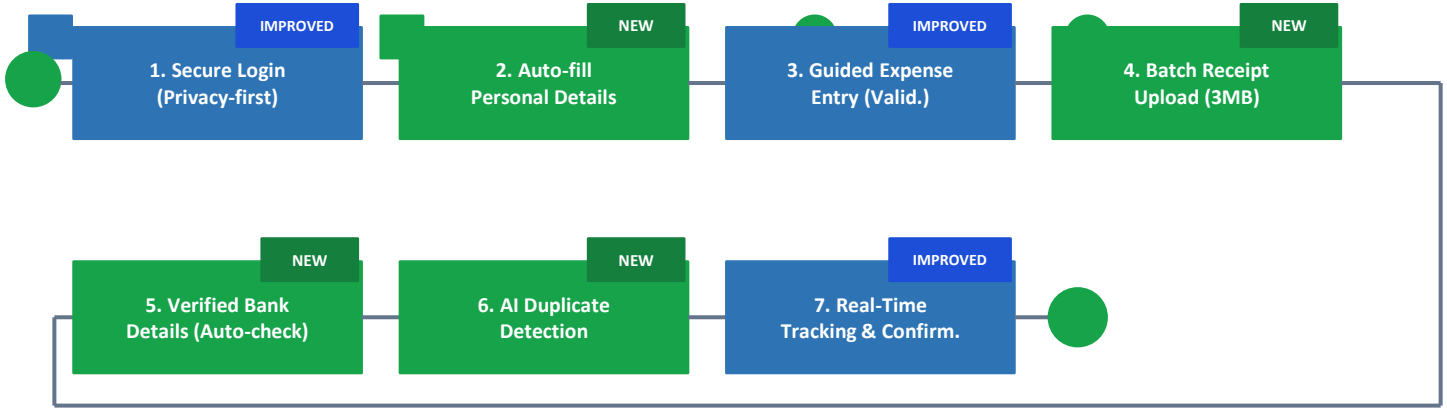
9-step flow with 5 bottlenecks — failures embedded in the design.



BOTTLENECKS IDENTIFIED

Step 2	Privacy violation — personal data (DOB, email, address) displayed immediately after login, visible in public spaces
Step 3	No input validation — free-text date fields accept wrong formats silently; errors surface only at final submission
Step 6	Sequential receipt upload locked to 2MB — forces users to abandon; batch upload not possible
Step 8	Bank details entered manually with zero validation — creates months-long payment failure loops

Redesigned to 7 steps — with built-in validation and smart automation.



KEY IMPROVEMENTS vs AS-IS

9 → 7 steps	3 redundant steps eliminated through automation and combined screens
Privacy fixed	Personal data hidden by default post-login — menu shown first, not raw profile data
Validation added	Date pickers replace free-text; bank account auto-verified before submission is accepted
Batch upload	All receipts uploaded at journey end (PDF/PNG/BMP, 3MB) — sequential lock removed

Two-phase roadmap: immediate wins first, then strategic transformation.

PHASE 1 — QUICK WINS · Total: $320K

Interactive Training Curriculum

Cost: $70K

Addresses 30% of support emails, reduces user errors, easy to deploy

-30% avoidable errors

Expand File Types & Upload Size

Cost: $250K

Increases accepted submissions by 30%, allows PDF/PNG and 3MB uploads

+30% submissions

PHASE 2 — STRATEGIC · Total: $1.55M

Virtual Chatbot Agent

Cost: $550K

Reduces erroneous submissions from 12% to below 5%

-7% error rate

OCR Technology

Cost: $600K

Automated data extraction reduces manual input time by 80%

-80% input time

Auto Reimbursement Tracker

Cost: $450K

Resolves 30% of emails and 40% of support tickets

-35% support load

Prioritisation Rationale

BCG 2x2 Impact/Effort Matrix applied to all 15 initiatives ($70K-$950K). Phase 1 selected for high impact at low cost. Phase 2 offers transformational outcomes once the baseline is stabilised. Complex external-dependency initiatives (university data sync, vendor lodging) explicitly deprioritised.

ISO 9001:2015 — Principle 5: Improvement · Recommendations are structured around measurable, iterative quality improvement cycles

From 53% failure to below 20%: a measurable, data-backed transformation.

BEFORE · Current State (As-Is)		AFTER · Projected State (To-Be)
53% submission failure rate	-62% failure	<20% failure rate (-33 pts)
55% login bounce rate	-30 pts	~25% bounce rate expected
Staff spend 60%+ time on error fix	-40% ops burden	Staff refocused on claim processing
12% erroneous submissions monthly	-7 pts	<5% with chatbot & validation
Receipt rejected: 2MB, JPG only	+30% uploads	3MB cap, PDF/PNG/BMP accepted

Total investment: $1.87M (Phase 1 + 2) · Reduced operational costs + higher grant disbursement efficiency · Timeline: 6-9 months

What this case study demonstrated.

01

Structured Problem Solving

Defined the problem with quantitative precision (53% failure, 55% bounce). Applied a hypothesis-driven approach to identify root causes before proposing solutions — avoiding premature recommendations.

02

Multi-Source Analysis

Triangulated insights across Excel data, user feedback, staff feedback and process mapping. Every recommendation is traceable to a specific data point or user pain — no assumptions.

03

Strategic Prioritisation

Evaluated a $7.8M initiative portfolio using BCG 2x2 methodology. Delivered a phased, cost-aware roadmap demonstrating the consulting discipline of balancing impact with implementation feasibility.

CONSULTING SKILLS APPLIED:

- Data Analysis
- Process Mapping (BPMN)
- Stakeholder Research
- Strategic Prioritisation
- Roadmap Design
- ISO 9001 QMS